

Stakeholder_Conflict_Resolution

Stakeholder Conflict Resolution - EA Scenarios

Purpose: Document real-world conflict resolution scenarios for Enterprise Architects

Scenario: Technology Choice Conflict

CONFLICT SCENARIO: Technology Choice
PROJECT: New Customer Onboarding System for Gaming Platform STAKEHOLDER: Head of Operations (Business) MY ROLE: Enterprise Architect

The Conflict

THE PROBLEM
<u>BUSINESS STAKEHOLDER WANTED:</u> "Buy a ready-made vendor solution (Salesforce) for customer onboarding" Their reasoning: • Faster time to market (2 months) • Proven solution, less risk • Vendor support available • "I've used it before at my previous company" ARCHITECTURE RECOMMENDATION:

"Build a custom microservice integrated with existing platform"

Our reasoning:

- Better integration with existing gaming platform
 - No vendor lock-in
 - Lower long-term cost
 - Aligned with architecture principles
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THE CONFLICT:

"Business wants to BUY, Architecture wants to BUILD"

Stakeholder was frustrated:

"You architects always want to build everything! You're blocking my project!"

Resolution Approach

Step 1: LISTEN First

STEP 1: LISTEN & UNDERSTAND

Instead of defending architecture position, I asked:

- "Help me understand – what's driving the urgency?"
- "What specific features are most important to you?"
- "What concerns do you have with building custom?"
- "Tell me about your experience with Salesforce before"

WHAT I LEARNED:

- Marketing campaign launching in 3 months (hard deadline)
- KYC verification was the critical feature
- Previous company had good Salesforce experience
- Fear that custom build would be delayed (past experience)

KEY INSIGHT:

The REAL concern was TIME and RISK, not Salesforce specifically

Step 2: ACKNOWLEDGE Concerns

STEP 2: ACKNOWLEDGE (Don't Dismiss)

What I said:

"You're absolutely right that:

- Time to market is critical for business success
- Vendor solutions reduce implementation risk
- Past custom builds have had delays
- Your experience with Salesforce is valuable"

"These are valid concerns and I want to address them, not dismiss them"

WHY THIS MATTERS:

- Stakeholder felt HEARD, not blocked
- Reduced defensive posture
- Opened dialog for collaboration

Step 3: PRESENT Data**STEP 3: PRESENT DATA & ANALYSIS**

I prepared a comparison (shared in next meeting):

Criteria	Salesforce (Buy)	Custom Build
Time to MVP	2 months	3 months
Integration effort	4 months additional	Included
Year 1 Cost	\$500K (license+impl)	\$300K
Year 2-5 Cost	\$200K/year license	\$50K/year maint
5-Year Total Cost	\$1.3M	\$500K
Integration risk	HIGH (different tech)	LOW (same stack)
Vendor lock-in	YES	NO
Gaming-specific KYC	Customization needed	Built for us

KEY FINDING:

Salesforce MVP = 2 months, BUT integration with gaming platform = 4 more months
TOTAL time with Salesforce = 6 months (LONGER than custom!)

Step 4: FIND Common Ground

STEP 4: PROPOSE COMPROMISE

My proposal addressed THEIR concerns:

"What if we do this:

1. BUILD custom onboarding service (3 months)
BUT use a 3RD PARTY KYC vendor (Jumio) for verification
→ Addresses time concern (proven KYC component)
2. PHASE 1: Core onboarding + Jumio KYC (3 months) ✓ Meets deadline
PHASE 2: Advanced features (2 months later)
→ Addresses risk concern (smaller scope first)
3. Weekly demos to business stakeholders
→ Addresses visibility concern (no surprises)
4. Architecture team commits to 3-month deadline with penalty clause
→ Addresses trust concern (skin in the game)"

COMPROMISE:

- Business gets: Speed, proven KYC, visibility, commitment
- Architecture gets: Custom build, no vendor lock-in, platform alignment

Step 5: DOCUMENT Agreement**STEP 5: DOCUMENT & COMMIT**

Created ADR (Architecture Decision Record):

ADR-015: Customer Onboarding Approach

Decision: Build custom service with Jumio KYC integration

Options Considered:

- Salesforce (rejected - integration time, cost)
- Full custom (rejected - KYC complexity)
- Hybrid: Custom + Jumio (SELECTED)

Stakeholders: Head of Operations (agreed), CTO (approved)

Commitments:

- Phase 1 delivery: 3 months
- Weekly demos every Friday
- Go/No-Go checkpoint at week 6

The Outcome

OUTCOME
RESULT: ✔ Delivered Phase 1 in 2.5 months (ahead of schedule!) ✔ Marketing campaign launched on time ✔ 5-year cost savings: \$800K vs Salesforce ✔ Seamless integration with gaming platform ✔ Stakeholder became architecture advocate RELATIONSHIP: • Head of Operations became ally, not adversary • Now consults architecture early on new initiatives • Trusts architecture recommendations LESSON LEARNED: "The conflict was never about Salesforce vs Custom. It was about TRUST, TIME, and RISK. Address the REAL concerns, not the surface argument."

Conflict Resolution Framework

5-STEP CONFLICT RESOLUTION FRAMEWORK	
1. LISTEN FIRST	- Understand their perspective, ask questions
2. ACKNOWLEDGE	- Validate their concerns (don't dismiss)
3. PRESENT DATA	- Facts, not opinions; show analysis
4. FIND COMMON GROUND	- Compromise that addresses both sides
5. DOCUMENT	- ADR, commitments, checkpoints

Communication Tips

NEVER SAY

"You're wrong"

"Architecture says no"

"That won't work"

"We always build custom"

"That's not how we do things"

INSTEAD SAY

"Help me understand..."

"Let's look at the options together"

"What if we tried..."

"What's most important to you?"

"Let me share our approach and get your input"

Key Takeaways

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Stakeholders aren't enemies – they have valid business concerns
- Architecture serves business, not the other way around
- Win-win solutions build long-term trust
- Address the REAL concerns (often hidden), not surface arguments
- Data beats opinions in resolving conflicts
- Document agreements to prevent future misunderstandings
- Follow through on commitments to build credibility

Interview Answer Template

When asked about stakeholder conflicts in interviews, structure your answer using **STAR**:

Situation: "In my previous role, we had a conflict about technology choice for a new onboarding system..."

Task: "As the Enterprise Architect, I needed to resolve this while maintaining platform alignment..."

Action: "I followed a 5-step approach: Listen, Acknowledge, Present Data, Find Common Ground, Document..."

Result: "We delivered ahead of schedule, saved \$800K over 5 years, and the stakeholder became an architecture advocate..."